I squinted. You feel you *have* to say yes? Does that mean you are saying yes? But that you want to say no?

I didn't get it. Was she being sarcastic? Ironic? Deliberately cryptic? Was she indulging in a bit of wordplay? I'd never known Granny to do any wordplay, and this would be a surpassingly bizarre moment (not to mention wildly inconvenient) for her to start, but maybe she just saw the chance to play off my unfortunate use of the word "have" and couldn't resist?

Or else, perhaps there was some hidden meaning beneath the wordplay, some message I wasn't comprehending?

I stood there squinting, smiling, asking myself over and over: What is the Queen of England saying to me right now?

At long last I realized: She's saying yes, you muppet! She's granting permission. Who cares how she words it, just know when to take yes for an answer.

So I sputtered: *Right. OK, Granny! Well. Fabulous. Thank you! Thank you so much.*

I wanted to hug her.

I longed to hug her.

I didn't hug her.

I saw her into the Range Rover, then marched back to Pa and Willy.

34.

I TOOK A RING from Meg's jewelry box and gave it to a designer, so he'd know her size.

Since he was also the keeper of Mummy's bracelets, earrings and necklaces, I asked him to harvest the diamonds from one particularly beautiful bracelet of Mummy's and use those to create a ring.

I'd cleared all this in advance with Willy. I'd asked my brother if I could have the bracelet, and told him what it was for. I don't recall him hesitating, for one second, in giving it to me. He seemed to *like* Meg, despite his oft-cited concerns. Kate seemed to like her too. We'd had them over for dinner during